

SAA Appointed Group Meeting

Technical Subcommittee on Encoded Archival Standards (TS-EAS)

May 26, 2026



Promoting the value and diversity of archives and archivists.

Agenda

- Introduction to TS-EAS
- Encoded Archival Standards and Next Steps
- Survey Results
- Breakout Groups
- Wrap-up

Technical Subcommittee on Encoded Archival Standards (TS-EAS)



Who We Are

A subcommittee consisting of both SAA and international members operating in nine different time zones. TS-EAS is responsible for the ongoing maintenance of encoded archival standards, including all schemas and related code, as well as the development of future companion standards.



Encoded Archival Standards

Purpose of Standards Suite

International, XML-based standards for structuring and sharing archival descriptive information. The standards include EAD, EAC-CPF, and EAC-F.

“Alignment by Design”

The three standards will share one revision cycle and establish a common base of shared elements and attributes to facilitate easier reuse and recognition.

Purposes of Encoding Standards

Consistency: so that the same type of information is recorded in the same way, making records comparable and aggregable. A date is a date, a name is a name, in a predictable place and format.

Interoperability: so that systems can exchange and use each other's data without custom translation for every pair of systems.

Longevity: so that information remains usable as systems change. Imagine if we had to write custom scripts for every piece of information each time we migrated to a new system.

Discovery: consistent and connected description means that researchers can find materials across institutions and uncover relationships between content

Expression of professional values: standards codify a community's consensus about what good archival description should be. And sometimes the conversations to create those standards is as important as the standard itself.

Encoded Archival Standards

The Benefits of Shared Standards

Sustainable

- Supports ongoing and future revisions as an integrated suite.
- Better suited to keep up with evolving standards landscape.
- Facilitates revision based on community needs.

1

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Usable

- Shared structure makes standards easier to use.
- Simplified design reduces learning barriers.
- Standards work independently or as a suite.
- Supports holistic view of metadata.

3

Efficient

- Saves time by keeping standards in sync.
- Streamlines through shared elements and attributes.
- Simplifies administration with a single revision cycle.
- Shifts from misalignment to intentional alignment.

Encoded Archival Standards

Who Might Use These Standards?

Cultural Heritage professionals

Developers and aggregators

Educators

Updates/Get Involved

Attend SAA session on July 31st for the official EAS release

Submit articles for the Best Practices Guide

Encoded Archival Description (EAD)

[Encoded Archival Description \(EAD\)](#)

SAA maintained standard

Maintaining group: Technical Subcommittee on Encoded Archival Standards
(TS-EAS)

Encoded Archival Description (EAD)

Encoded Archival Description (EAD)

Purpose of Standard

XML standard for encoding descriptions of archival materials. EAD facilitates sharing and discovery of collection descriptions.

- Release history
 - EAD 1.0 (1998)
 - EAD 2002 (2002 (2006 as XML-schema))
 - EAD3 (2015)
 - EAD 4 (2026)
- Based on the International Standard Archival Description (General) (ISAD(G)) standard (2000)
- Content guidelines available in Describing Archives: A Content Standard (DACS) Part I

Encoded Archival Context - Corporate bodies, Persons, and Families (EAC-CPF)

[Encoded Archival Context - Corporate bodies, Persons, and Families \(EAC-CPF\)](#)

SAA maintained standard

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Encoded Archival Context - Corporate bodies, Persons, and Families (EAC-CPF)

Encoded Archival Context - Corporate bodies, Persons, and Families (EAC-CPF)

Purpose of Standard

XML standards for encoding the description of individuals, families and corporate bodies that create, preserve, use and are responsible for and/or associated with records in a variety of ways.

- Release history
 - EAC Beta (2004)
 - EAC-CPF 1.0 (2010)
 - EAC-CPF 2.0 (2022)
 - EAC-CPF 3.0 (2026)
- Based on the International Standard Archival Authority Record for Corporate bodies, Persons, and Families (ISAAR(CPF)) standard (2003)
- Content guidelines available in Describing Archives: A Content Standard (DACS) Part II

Encoded Archival Context - Functions (EAC-F)

SAA maintained standard

Maintaining group: Technical Subcommittee on Encoded Archival Standards
(TS-EAS)

Encoded Archival Context – Functions (EAC-F)

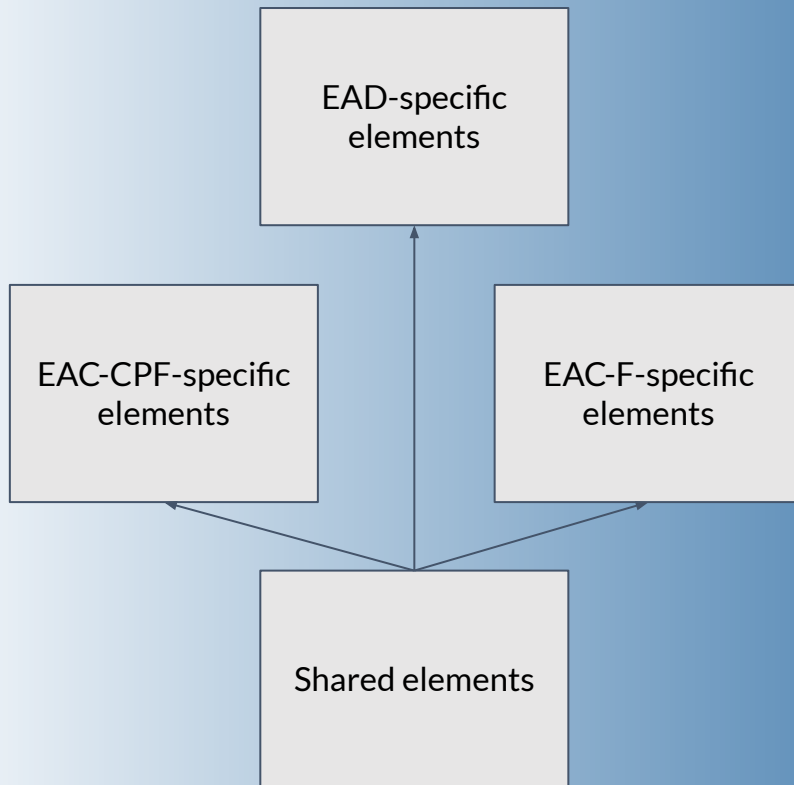
Purpose of Standard

XML standard for encoding functions performed by agents resulting in records.

- Release history
 - EAC-F 1.0 (2026)
- Based on the International Standard for Describing Functions (ISDF) standard (2007)
- Work started with ad-hoc group in 2013
 - Information gathering was the focus for 2013
 - Group became dormant shortly after the meeting
- In 2016 TS-EAS began work on the creation of EAC-F
- No content guidelines provided in Describing Archives: A Content Standard (DACS), but listed as an entity in Principle 4

Upcoming Changes to the Standards - Highlights

Shared elements and attributes



Upcoming Changes to the Standards - Highlights

Human-readable element names (camelCasing)

<odd>



<otherDescriptiveInfo>

Upcoming Changes to the Standards - Highlights

Updates to recording relationships

EAD3

<origination> <relations>
<controlaccess>

EAD 4

<agent>
<place>
<subject>
<function>

Upcoming Changes to the Standards - Highlights

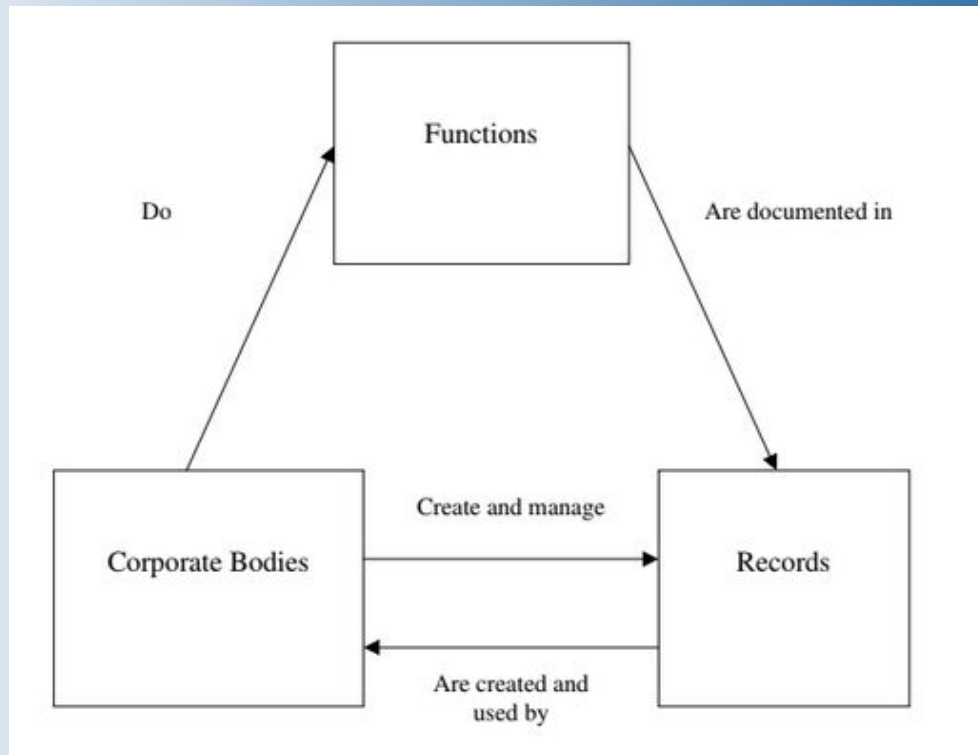
Extensibility

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<ead
xmlns="https://archivists.org/ns/ead/v4"
xmlns:xsi="http://www.w3.org/2001/XMLSchema
-instance"
xmlns:marc21="http://www.loc.gov/MARC21/sl
im"
xsi:schemalocation="https://archivists.org
/ns/ead/v4 http://www.loc.gov/MARC21/slim
https://www.loc.gov/standards/marcxml/sche
ma/MARC21slim.xsd">
  <control>
    <!-- control subelements -->
  </control>
  <archdesc level="collection">
    <identificationData>
      <unitTitle marc21:tag="245">A. Dean
Larsen Book Collecting Conference
records</unitTitle>
      <!-- identificationData subelements
-->
    </identificationData>
  </archdesc>
</ead>
```

Upcoming Changes to the Standards - Highlights

Functions

- A new standard supported by the TS-EAS user community.
- Provides a thorough description of a function and the relation to other functions and activities.
- EAD retains a <function> element to describe a relationship between a function and archival materials.
- EAC-CPF retains a <functionPerformed> element to describe a relationship between a function and archival creator.
- If a function description in EAC-F is available use a relation in EAD or EAC-CPF.



Standards in Practice

Findings from a Community Survey on Encoded Archival Standards

Cory Nimer

Outreach and Communications Subcommittee

Encoded Archival Standards Community Survey

- Survey sought to measure archivist engagement with standards and training needs
- Developed by the Outreach and Communications Subteam
 - Questions based on previous TS-EAS EAD3 implementation survey (2019) and the EAS Section survey (2020)
- Survey available in Google Form from March-April 2026
- Participants self selected based on open call

Encoded Archival Standards Community Survey

The Technical Subcommittee on Encoded Archival Standards (TS-EAS) is exploring community implementation and use of archival encoding standards and systems. This survey is intended to help TS-EAS better understand the usage of these standards and to guide its outreach and communications program.

The survey should take approximately 5-10 minutes to complete, and all responses are anonymous and will be kept confidential. The final results of the survey will be reported only in aggregate.

Participation in this survey is voluntary and you may stop the survey at any time. This survey provides no direct benefit to you, but it may help improve outreach and training opportunities related to encoded archival standards.

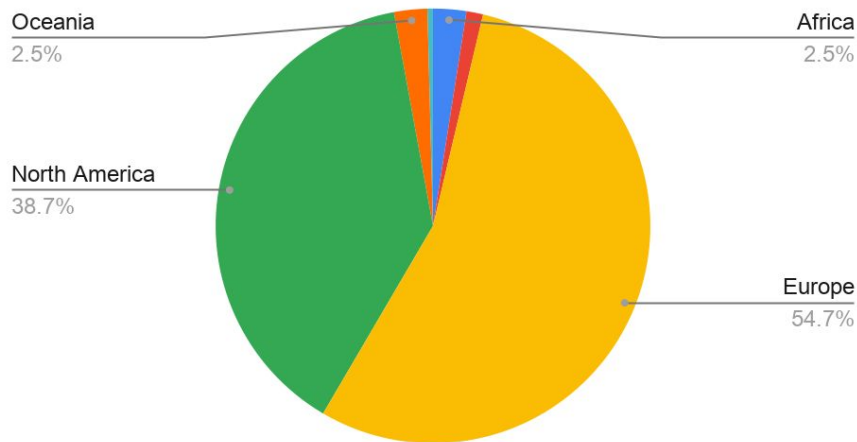
The survey will remain available until Friday, April 3, 2026. If you have any questions about the survey, please contact the committee at ts-eas@archivists.org.

[Next](#)[Clear form](#)

Encoded Archival Standards Community Survey

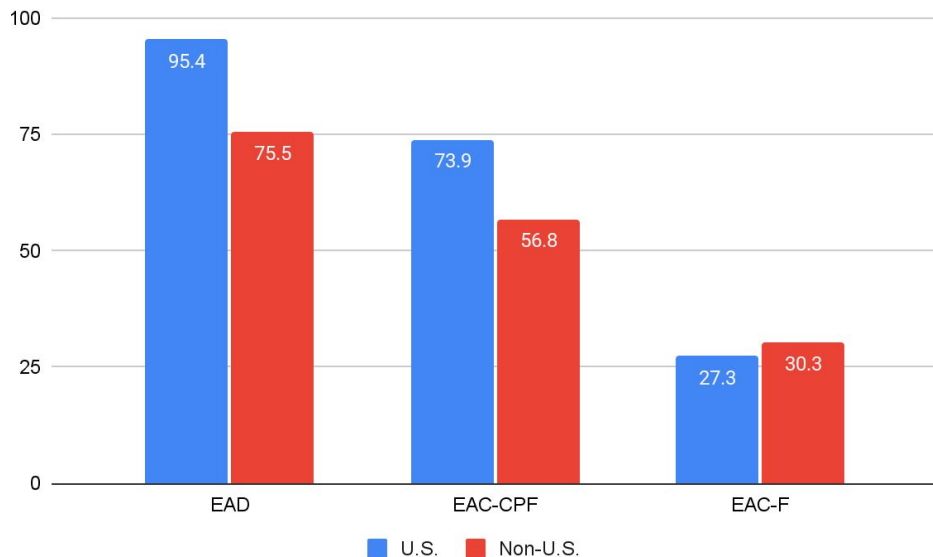
- Strong international participation in survey
- Diverse representation from repository types
- High levels of education and professional certification

Respondents by location



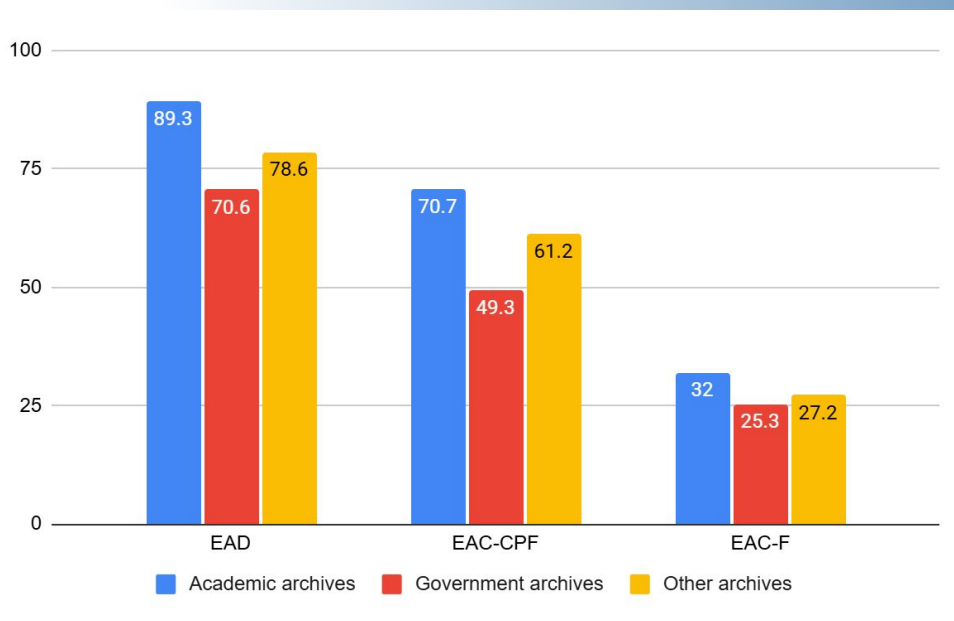
Encoded Archival Standards Community Survey

- Varying levels of familiarity with archival encoding standards
- Greater saturation in the United States than elsewhere



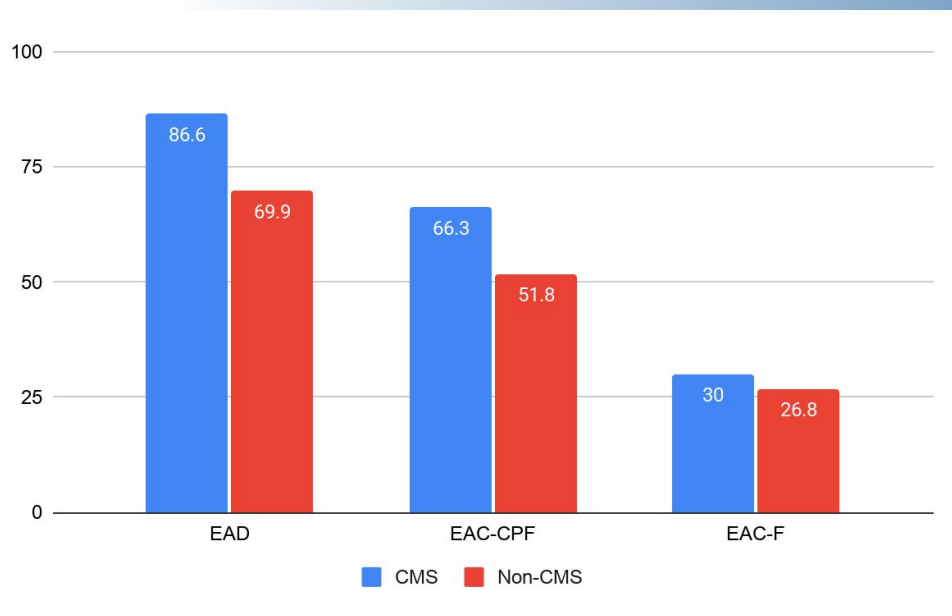
Encoded Archival Standards Community Survey

- Standards familiarity also varied by institution type
 - Academic archivists tended to be more aware than government archivists



Encoded Archival Standards Community Survey

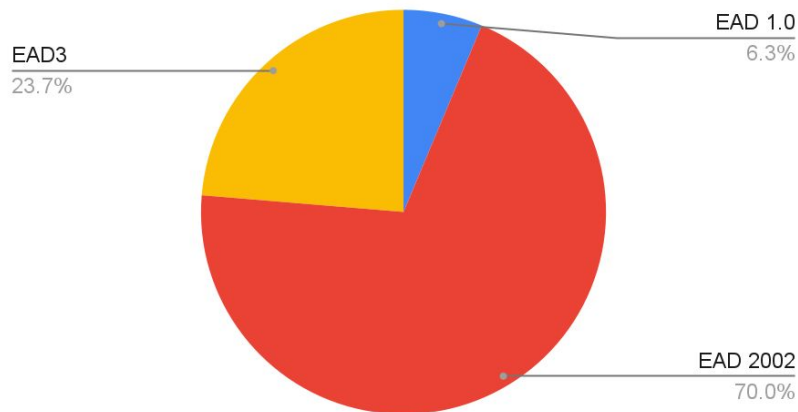
- Majority of archivists working in a CMS (77 percent)
 - Archivists at these institutions more informed about standards than peers



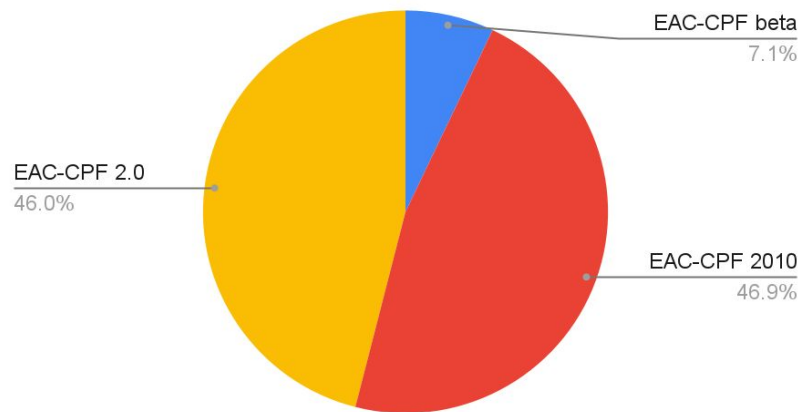
Encoded Archival Standards Community Survey

- Multiple versions of standards remain in use
 - EAD 2002 dominant, though greater EAD3 adoption levels in the U.S.

Encoded Archival Description

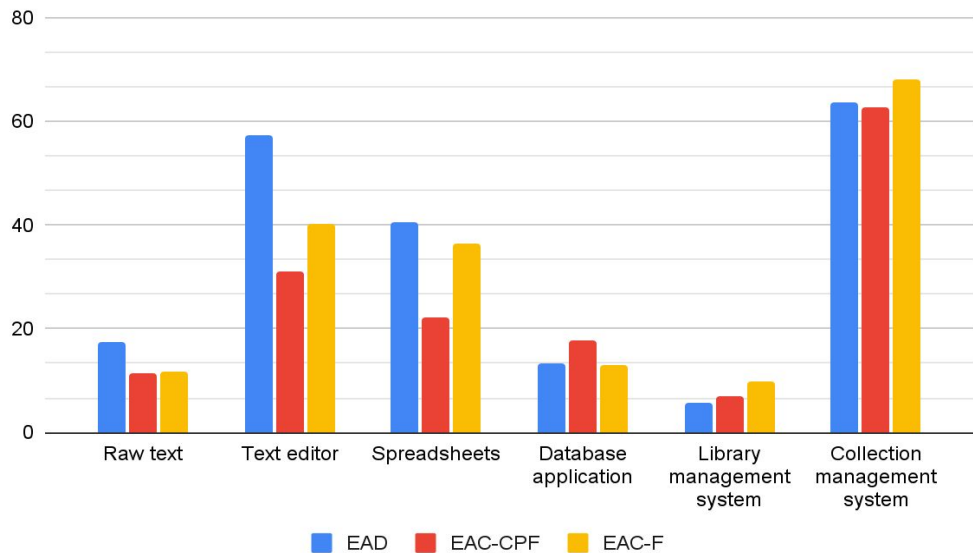


Encoded Archival Context--Corporate bodies,



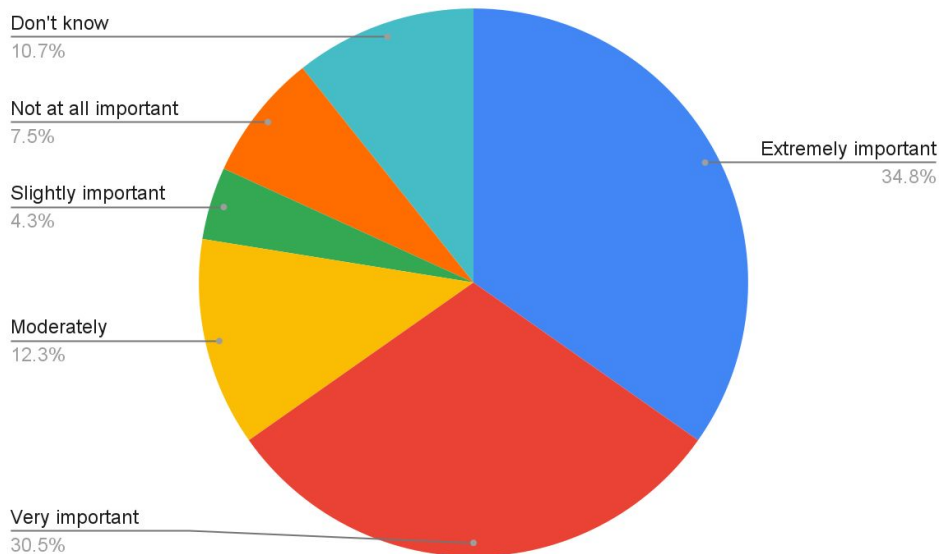
Encoded Archival Standards Community Survey

- CMS were most common method for using archival encoding standards
- Text editors and spreadsheets remained popular tools



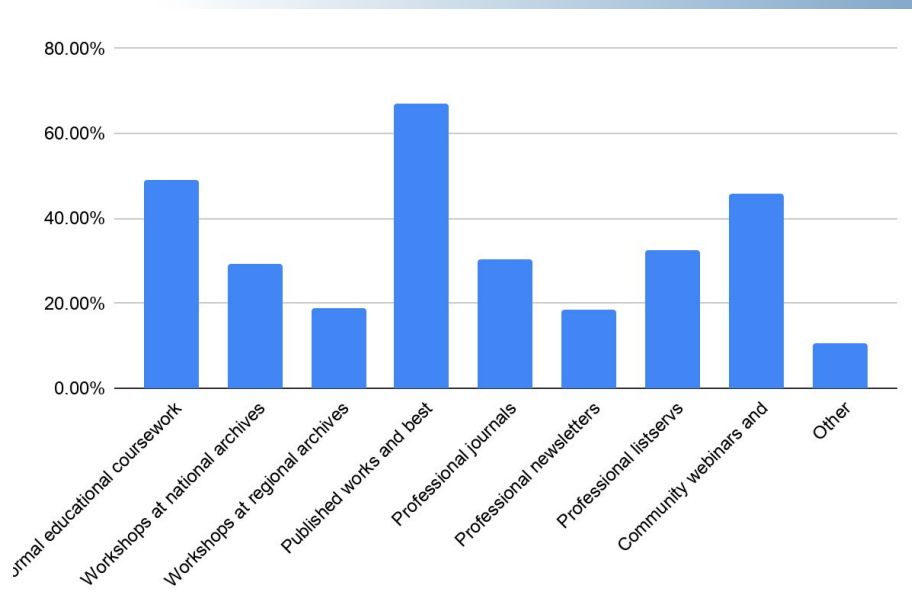
Encoded Archival Standards Community Survey

- Standards-compliance is important for archivists in selecting a CMS
 - Over 3/4 of respondents indicated at least moderate importance



Encoded Archival Standards Community Survey

- Archivists have studied encoding standards in various ways
- Publications, formal coursework, and webinars most preferred methods



Encoded Archival Standards Community Survey

- Respondents saw a role for TS-EAS in supporting learning
- Significant number called for more non-English content and outreach



Encoded Archival Standards Community Survey

- Discussion group exercise
 - Three breakout groups, one for each standard
 - 20 minutes for discussion, 15 minutes for group reports and comments
- Questions to consider:
 - How might we increase awareness of this standard, and where should those efforts be focused?
 - How can we encourage adoption or migration to current versions of the standard?
 - How do we collaborate with software developers to support the standard?
 - What other tools or training are needed to support implementation?
 - What trainings or webinars should we focus on developing, and how do we share the information?

Thank you!

Questions?

For more information:

- SAA page: <https://www2.archivists.org/groups/technical-subcommittee-on-encoded-archival-standards-ts-eas>
- GitHub: <https://github.com/SAA-SDT/>
- Contact us @ <https://www2.archivists.org/standards/TS-EAS-report-an-issue>